



THE DOWNTURN Dhananjay Singh being taken into custody after the March 6 ruling by a court in Jaunpur; (inset) wife Shrikala Reddy

at. She has been meeting supporters, and sources say contesting the Jaunpur LS seat as an independent might be on the cards. A section in the Samajwadi Party (SP) also wants the party to field her; Jaunpur was one its few successes in 2019.

THE PURVANCHAL UNDERBELLY

The Yogi Adityanath government may make tall claims about ending the "mafia raj" in the state, but this is election season, and every party is looking to keep these strongmen on their side. This has been especially true of Purvanchal, including Yogi's home turf Gorakhpur and its neighbouring areas which have produced some of UP's biggest *bahubali*s since the 1980s. The murders and counter-strikes had even attracted the attentions of the foreign media then, with headlines that screamed 'Chicago of the East' and 'Slice of Sicily'.

Many of the biggest *bahubali*s today were all products of the trouble-torn 1980s and '90s. Apart from Dhananjay, another muscleman in the limelight is Amanmani Tripathi, son of former minister Amarmani Tripathi, who was convicted along with his wife Madhumani Tripathi for the murder of poet Madhumita Shukla. The couple were sentenced to life imprisonment in 2007, but were 'prematurely released' by the UP government in August 2023.

Amarmani is a former four-time MLA and minister and, again, a veteran of the Thakur-Brahmin caste wars. He is also a long-time acquaintance of CM Adityanath, a relationship that sources say started in Gorakhpur Divisional Jail in 2007 where the latter was lodged for a brief while in a hate crime case.

The Congress decision to induct Amanmani, a former MLA of Nautanwa in Maharajganj district, has stumped many, and not just in the party. Tripathi Jr was a self-proclaimed acolyte of the CM, losing no occasion to proclaim his fealty. Perplexed state Congress leaders say the decision "was taken by Delhi", perhaps to improve the party footprint in eastern UP and also reach out to the Brahmin community. According to a CBI chargesheet filed in 2015, Amanmani strangled his wife Sara Singh to death. He is currently out on bail.

Amanmani's induction has ruffled feathers in the Congress as he is seeking an LS ticket from Maharajganj where national spokesperson Supriya Shrinate and Pharenda MLA Virendra Chaudhary are among the probables. Chaudhary, though, seems to be the frontrunner. "He should be nominated (for the Maharajganj seat), but a final call will be taken by the central leadership," says a senior state leader.

Meanwhile, some of yesterday's kingpins, especially from the Muslim community, are trying to keep a low profile and not paint too much outside the margins. Afzal Ansari, BSP MP and brother of gangster-turned-neta Mukhtar Ansari, has got a ticket from the SP this time for the Ghazipur seat. Party chief Akhilesh Yadav, a key component of the Opposition I.N.D.I.A. bloc, even attended Afzal's daughter's wedding in Lucknow,